

Why Should College Be Free?

By [College Raptor Staff](#) Last updated on September 22, 2025

Key Takeaways:

- Some arguments in favor of free college include the ideas that it could help lower student debt, close income gaps, and reduce stress.
- However, it's not quite clear where the funding would come from for free college, and there's worries that it would diminish a degree's value.
- Other programs, including targeted scholarships, free community college, and repayment plans, could make it easier for students to access and afford higher education.



“Should college be free?” is an oft-asked question with a complicated and arguably unclear answer, especially in the face of rising college costs and student debt. Some argue, with evidence, that it could help close the inequality gap, encourage learning, and work to develop a better workforce. On the other hand, it's not entirely clear where the funding for free college would come from or how it would affect the quality of high education.

Below, we broke down the possible benefits and the downsides to try to get to the answer of “Should college be free?”

Why Should College Be Free?

There are several upsides to making college free within the United States. It could bring a number of benefits to up-and-coming generations and students looking to return to college after a break. Here are six arguments in favor.

1. Student Debt Would No Longer Crush the Younger Generations

If an American college student is able to graduate with less than \$10,000 in student loan debt, they are considered lucky (the current average is around \$38,375 in federal student loan debt alone). Students from other countries that already offer free college don't have much student loan debt, if any. Most of their costs are living expenses, books, and materials.

Without the weight of student loan debt, more college graduates could have the opportunity to buy houses and cars sooner rather than later. More money also makes it easier to afford healthier food options, healthcare, and basic needs.

And, of course, with less debt generally comes less stress. With 73% of people in the United States saying finances are the number one stress in their lives, the lack of student debt just as they're entering the workforce could be a game changer for younger generations.

2. Free College Could Help Lessen the Current Inequality Gap

There are plenty of students who would love to go to college but simply can't due to the excessive cost of attendance. Some even have to drop out because they don't have the ability to pay for tuition for all four years – over 50% of students drop out of public universities because they can't afford it! 79% also delay their graduation because they have to switch to part-time or return at a later date due to costs.

While there are grants and scholarship programs to help make college more affordable for these students, it sometimes isn't enough and there's only so much money to go around. Making college free could help eliminate this reason for not graduating and improve college graduation rates.

Other considerations include:

- There are income gaps between potential average earnings for college graduates and those with only a high school diploma.
- Those without college degrees are more likely to divorce.
- College expansion has been shown to decrease crime.
- College education has been shown to increase community participation.



3. More Freedom and Less Stress

When entering college, many students are concerned about the earning potential of their major. Additional pressure can come from parents, family members, and society as a whole. There's also the concern about having a lucrative job after graduation so you can pay back that debt. These factors can result in students opting for "practical" majors that are much more geared towards income rather than their passions and interests.



In turn, burnout could occur when a student is taking courses that they're simply not interested in, and financial concerns on top of this issue adds additional stress. If a student is constantly worried about affording their next semester's tuition or working a job to afford their bills, they're not focusing enough on their classwork. By allowing them to study what they want and taking the financial stress out of the equation, burnout is less likely to occur, resulting in higher grade potential and rising graduation rates.

4. More People Could Go to College

By negating the large cost of a college education, we could see an increase in the number of students able to attend college. Students who previously hadn't thought about attending college due to the cost may now be interested in attending.

5. There Could Be a Stronger Workforce

College offers more than courses related to the student's major and a chance to enter a specific career field. College education teaches several [skills](#) that can be difficult to master elsewhere. A range of available courses during the four years of college teaches students problem-solving, critical thinking, cooperation, communication, conflict resolution, networking, and more. These skills translate directly to the workplace which can improve productivity, efficiency, company culture, and overall performance.

6. It Could Help Drive Economic Growth

With free college there is potential to drive economic growth. If students graduate with little to no debt, they would have more money from their income to put back into the

economy. And thanks to the skills colleges teach, employees can help build new companies and industries.

Why Should College *Not* Be Free?

However, there are some arguments that need to be noted that challenge the “college should be free” idea, including these:

1. The Money Has to Come From Somewhere

If America were to move to a tuition-free college policy, where would the money come from? The short and simple answer is likely in the form of increased taxes. So, who would be paying for those? It could impact the upper middle class as well as those in higher income brackets. Or it might come from Wall Street speculation taxes.



2. College Might Not Be Taken Seriously

A tuition-free college experience may result in an increase in students not taking it seriously. Some students state that the realization of how much they or their family is paying drives them to perform well in college and actually attend their classes. If college was free, students might be more likely to skip classes, change their major, and study less.

There's also the concern that students would be more likely to take a course “here and there” rather than working towards degree requirements, which could take up valuable seats from those working towards a degree.

3. College Education and Experience Could Decrease in Quality

Another argument against “why should college be free” is the idea that quality could dip. With potentially less money going into colleges and universities, schools may find it more difficult to offer top-quality education opportunities for their students. Faculty and staff salaries could decrease, and colleges may find it difficult to afford new equipment or campus upkeep.

When students pay for their classes, they're not only paying for their seat – the payments also go towards salaries, library books, housing repairs, [campus resources](#), campus upkeep, and more.

4. More People Would Go to College

This was listed under the benefits of “why should college be free,” but the fact that more people would go to college could also be considered a downside. Some argue that free tuition means a college degree is worth less, resulting in lower pay for college graduates.

In addition, previous jobs that only required a bachelor’s could now require a master’s or higher, resulting in oversaturation and employees working jobs they’re overqualified for.

Plus, colleges only have so much space. Students might find it even more difficult to get into competitive colleges and waitlists could rise.